I'm sitting on the physiotherapy bed in our dressing room. Dale Steyn, Faf du Plessis and Farhaan Behardien are around, and we're enjoying the buzz of another 'pink' Sunday at the Wanderers, the annual ODI when the Proteas and most of the spectators dress in pink to raise funds for and awareness of the fight against breast cancer. I'm nervous. This is my 177th one-day international but I feel as anxious as I did during my first.

'It will never change,' I say out loud, to nobody in particular.

'What?' Faf asks.

'The nerves – I always get so nervous before I bat.'

As I speak, Rilee is caught in the deep, out for 128. Our score is 247 for one. I'm up next. I grab my bat and make my way down the stairs. As I do, I trip and stumble. Faf and Dale burst out laughing.

Emerging from the long path leading down to the field, limbering up, loosening up, whirling my arms, for a moment, I become aware of the amazing stage … a beautiful summer's day on the Highveld, the Bullring packed in pink, the Proteas going well, the crowd happy and excited. For an instant, I consider again how lucky I am to be playing this game for a living, to be representing my country and now to be captain of the national ODI team. That's enough emotion! I consciously snap back into the moment, block out the sentiment, the noise, the atmosphere and the bubbling anticipation. It's time to focus on the task, to find a way of getting back into the zone and settling into a rhythm, always respecting the opposition and the game, earning the right to express myself and play my game.

Hash has made 114 from 116 balls and he stands, waiting for me in the middle, so calm and controlled. We've been playing cricket with and against each other since we were teenagers, for school, province and country, and he's always been such a high-quality person and such a high-quality player.

'I'll have a look for one or two overs,' I tell him, 'and we'll go from there.'

The plan is simple: Hash bats through the innings and I settle as